3 Introduction to Classification

In Chapter 1, we examined various tasks that machine learning excels at, such as regression (predicting values) and classification (identifying classes). Having explored linear and polynomial regression in Chapter 2, we now turn our attention to classification in this section.

Review 3.1 In this chapter, we utilize the MNIST (Modified National Institute of Standards and Technology) dataset, a collection of 70,000 small images of handwritten digits. This dataset is known as "modified" because it combines two earlier sets of images: one created by U.S. high school students and another by US Census Bureau employees. First published in 1998, the dataset is particularly suitable for machine learning tasks as each image is labeled with the digit it represents. Each digit has been normalized and centered in a 28x28 pixel frame and anti-aliased to introduce grayscale levels.

Typically, the dataset is split into two parts: the first 60,000 images are used for training, and the remaining 10,000 serve as validation data. It is standard practice to train and test models on the first 60,000 images, reserving the last 10,000 for final validation at the end of the project when the classifier is ready for deployment.

Figure 3.1: A collection of the 10 digits (0-9) that make up the MNIST data set.

Scikit-Learn includes a helper function that facilitates the downloading of the MNIST dataset.

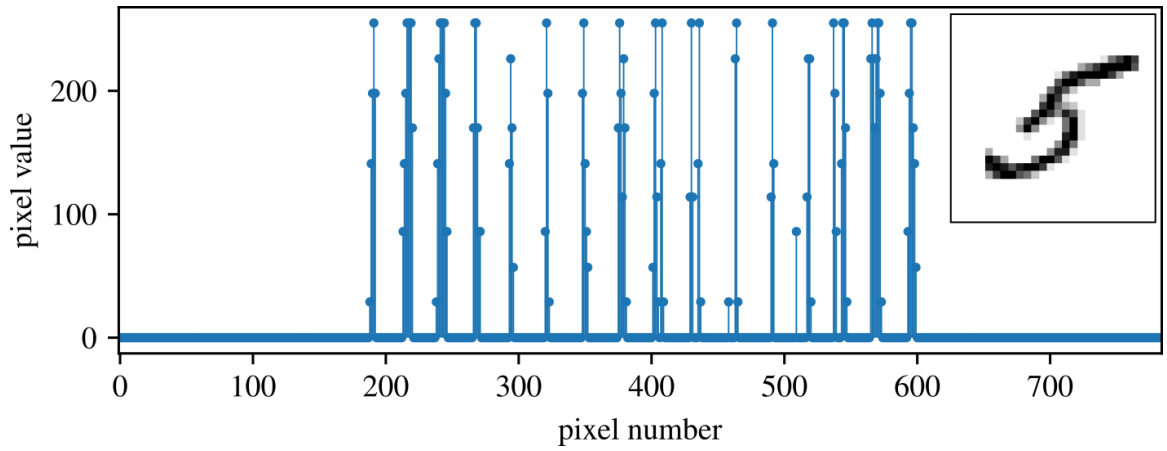

Figure 3.2: The 784 features that range from 0 to 256 and each represent an 8-bit gray scale pixel for a "5 digit" from the MNIST data set.

Example 3.1 Do example on loading MNIST data set.

3.1 Binary Classifier

To begin, we simplify our task by focusing on identifying all the "5"s in the MNIST dataset. This task involves using a binary classifier that checks whether each digit is a 5. The number 5 is notoriously difficult to classify correctly within the MNIST dataset, making it a sensible starting point for binary classification.

3.1.1 Linear Classifier Solved with Stochastic Gradient Descent

A practical algorithm for building this "5-detector" is the Stochastic Gradient Descent (SGD) classifier. The SGD classifier offers an efficient and straightforward approach for discriminative learning of linear classifiers under convex loss functions, scaling well with large datasets and maintaining simplicity in implementation as it processes one training example at a time. The main advantages of the Stochastic Gradient Descent classifier include:

- Efficiency.
- Ease of implementation, providing many opportunities for optimization.

However, the Stochastic Gradient Descent classifier also presents certain disadvantages:

- It requires careful tuning of several hyperparameters, including the regularization parameter and the number of iterations.
- It is sensitive to feature scaling.

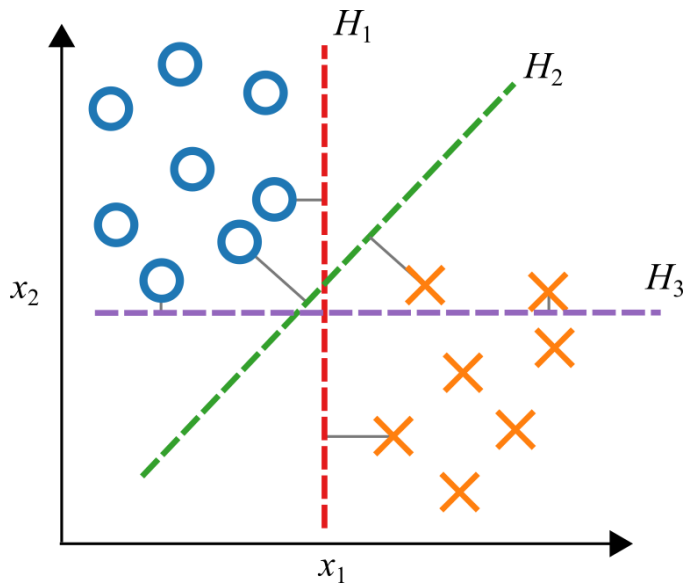

Figure 3.3: Linear classifier that can be implemented with gradient descent.

Example 3.2 Implement an example of MNIST using Stochastic Gradient Descent.

3.2 Performance Measures for Binary Classification

Assessing the performance of a classifier can be more intricate than evaluating a regressor. Nonetheless, there are numerous performance metrics available that facilitate the comprehensive evaluation of a classifier's effectiveness.

3.2.1 Confusion Matrix

First, a brief explanation of Type I and Type II errors. These terms are not exclusive to classification problems in machine learning; they are also crucial in statistical hypothesis testing:

Type I Error: False positive (incorrectly rejecting a true null hypothesis)

Type II Error: False negative (incorrectly failing to reject a false null hypothesis)

These four cases from statistical testing can be combined into a single matrix known as the confusion matrix. In the context of our 5-detector, consider the simplified confusion matrix shown in figure 3.4.

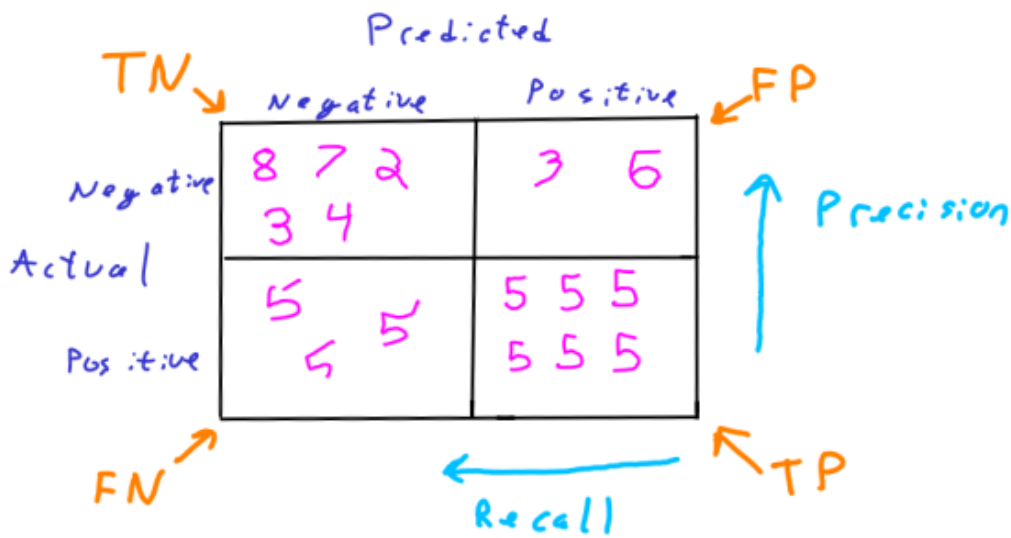

Figure 3.4: Confusion matrix binary.

A effective approach to evaluating classifier performance is to examine the confusion matrix. The essence is to tally the instances where class A is incorrectly classified as class B. A well-performing classifier will exhibit high values along the diagonal and lower values elsewhere in the matrix. Each row represents the actual class, while each column represents the predicted class. For instance, to determine how often the classifier misidentified images of 5s as 3s, inspect the intersection of the 5th row and 3rd column in figure 3.5.

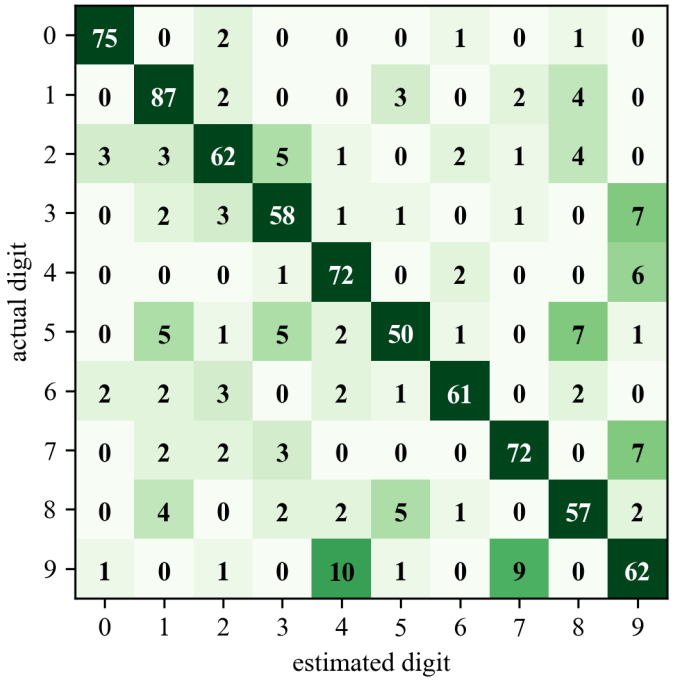

Figure 3.5: Confusion matrix for the first 1,000 data points from the MNIST dataset.

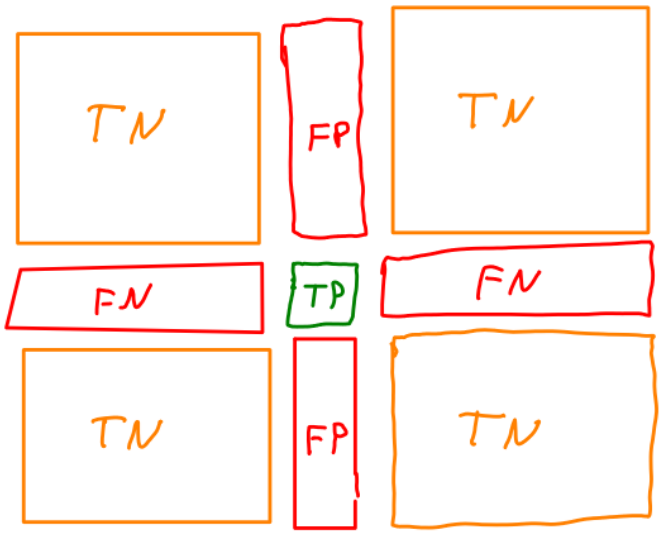

Figure 3.6: Confusion matrix breakout.

Each row in the confusion matrix corresponds to an actual class, while each column corresponds to a predicted class This is diagrammed in figure 3.6. The first row represents non-5 images (the negative class), and the second row represents images classified as 5s (the positive class). The first column of the first row indicates true negatives (TN), while the second column of the first row

shows false positives (FP). The second row denotes images of 5s (the positive class): the first column represents false negatives (FN), and the second column displays true positives (TP). A perfect classifier would only have nonzero values along the main diagonal (from top left to bottom right).

Example 3.3 Do example binary confusion matrix

3.2.2 Accuracy, Precision, and Recall

The confusion matrix provides detailed information, but sometimes a more concise metric is preferred. Before looking into accuracy, let's define it:

$$\text{Accuracy} = \frac{\text{Number of Correct Predictions}}{\text{Total number of Predictions}} \tag{3.3}$$

Or:

$$\text{Accuracy} = \frac{TP + TN}{TP + TN + FP + FN} \tag{3.4}$$

While accuracy offers valuable insights, it's essential to consider the number of falsely classified positive and negative predictions, especially within the context of the problem being addressed. For instance, a 99% accuracy rate might seem satisfactory for predicting credit card fraud. However, what if a false negative indicates a severe virus or cancer? This is why we need to look deeper into the accuracy formula.

This is where precision and recall come into play. With this in mind, let's define:

Precision: Precision measures the fraction of "selected relevant instances" over the "selected instances." Mathematically, precision is calculated as the true positives over predicted positives.

Recall: Recall measures the fraction of "selected relevant instances" over the "relevant instances." Mathematically, recall is calculated as true positives over actual positives.

While these definitions may not be immediately intuitive, a visualizations such as that shown in figure 3.7 can help clarify them.

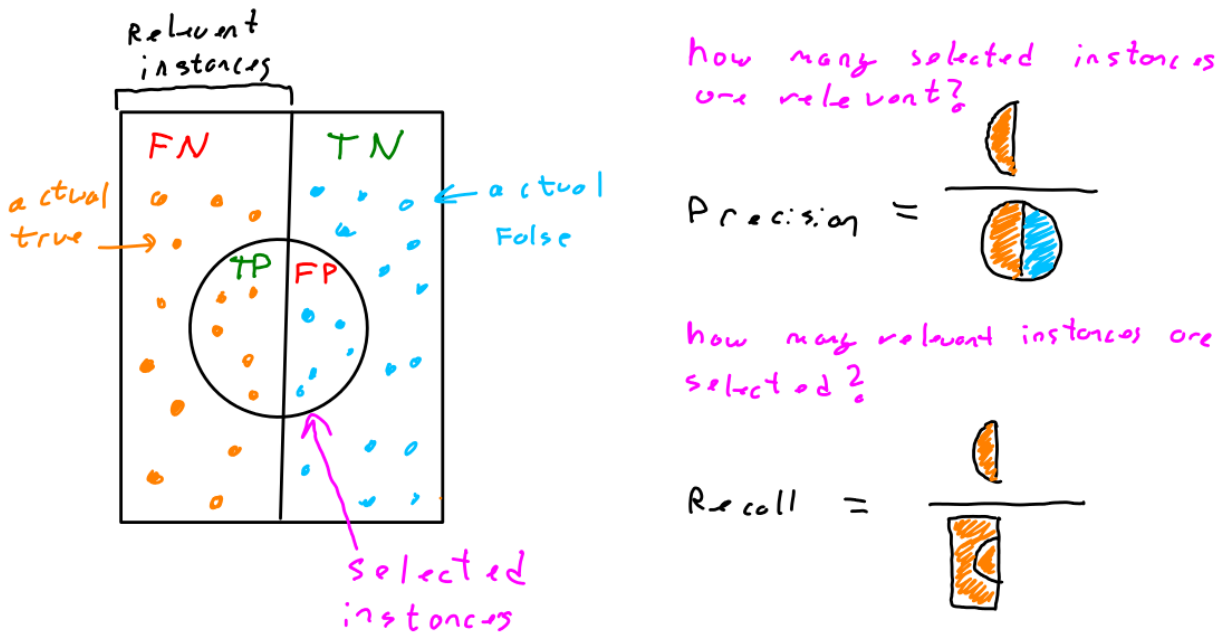

Figure 3.7: Visual representation of relevant instances, showing their relation to True Positives (TP) and False Positives (FP).

Definitions of instances:

$$\text{Selected instances} = TP + FP \tag{3.5}$$

$$\text{Relevant instances} = TP + FN \tag{3.6}$$

Now that we have a better understanding, let's examine some equations.

$$\text{Precision} = \frac{TP}{TP + FP} \tag{3.7}$$

Here, TP represents true positives, and FP represents false positives.

One way to achieve perfect precision is to make only one positive prediction and ensure it's correct (precision = 1/1 = 100%). However, this approach would be impractical as it would ignore most positive instances. Recall complements precision by considering all relevant results, both true positives and false negatives. Recall, also known as sensitivity or true positive rate (TPR), is the ratio of positive instances correctly detected by the classifier.

$$\text{Recall} = \frac{TP}{TP + FN} \tag{3.8}$$

To balance precision and recall, we often use the F1 score, which is the harmonic mean of precision and recall. The F1 score favors classifiers with similar precision and recall.

$$F_1 = \frac{2 \times \text{precision} \times \text{recall}}{\text{Precision} + \text{Recall}} = \frac{TP}{TP + \frac{FN+FP}{2}} \tag{3.9}$$

However, optimizing both precision and recall simultaneously is challenging due to the precision/recall tradeoff.

Figure 3.8 illustrates this tradeoff using the SGDClassifier's decision function. By adjusting the classification threshold, we can control the balance between precision and recall. Lowering the threshold increases recall but reduces precision, and vice versa.

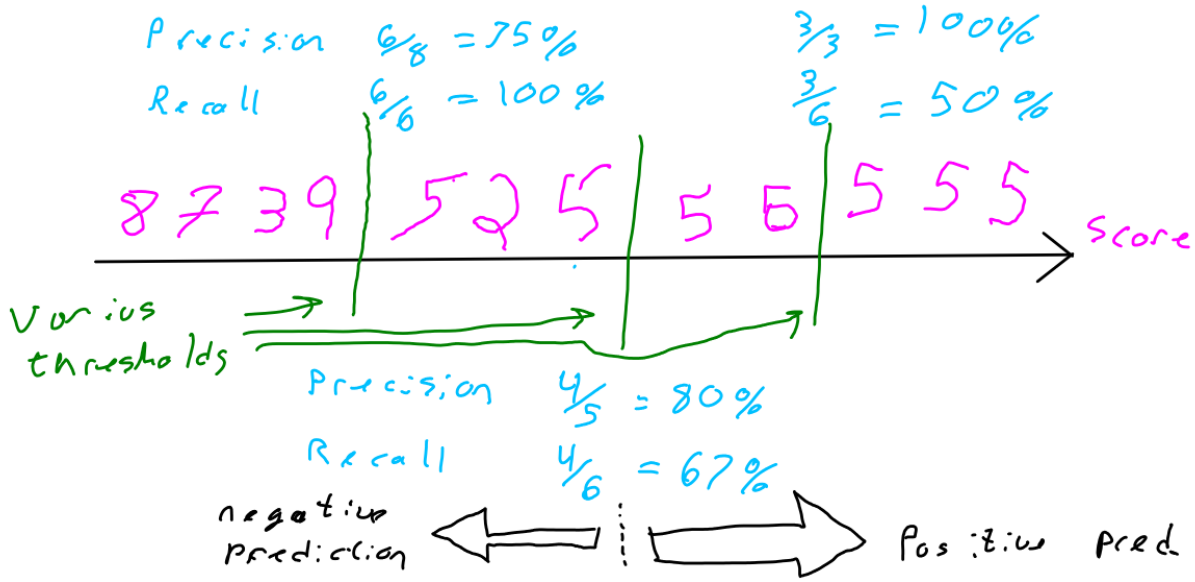

Figure 3.8: Visualization of the F1 score.

To determine the optimal threshold, it's helpful to plot precision and recall against the threshold values. By default, the classifier in scikit-learn uses a threshold of zero, but this can be adjusted as needed.

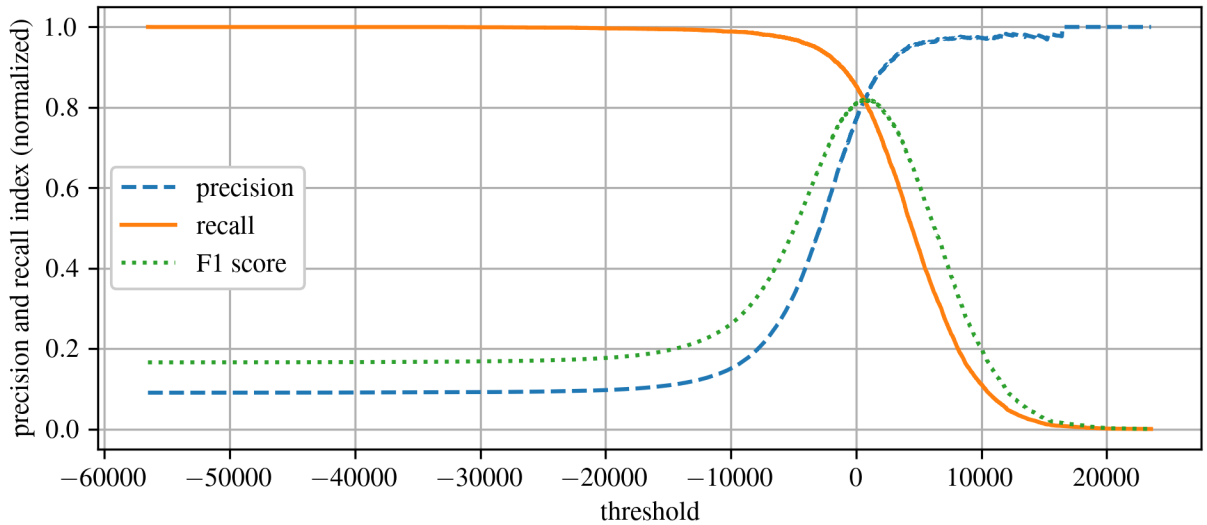

Figure 3.9: Visualization of the precision, recall, and F1 score as a function of changing a threshold value.

As illustrated in Figure 3.9, it's relatively straightforward to develop a classifier with nearly any desired precision: simply adjust the threshold to a sufficiently high value. However, it's important to bear in mind that a high-precision classifier may not be very practical if its recall is too low.

Example 3.4 Do example on precision, recall, and accuracy.

Figure 3.10 reports a precision vs recall curve that is obtained by changing the threshold of the trained model. At the leftmost part of the precision-recall curve (low recall), precision is highest because the model makes very few positive predictions, and those are likely true positives. As recall increases, the model starts predicting more positives, including more false positives, which reduces precision. The shape of the curve is also important; a steep drop-off indicates that the addition of false positives happens rapidly with increasing recall, whereas a more gradual decline suggests a better balance between precision and recall.

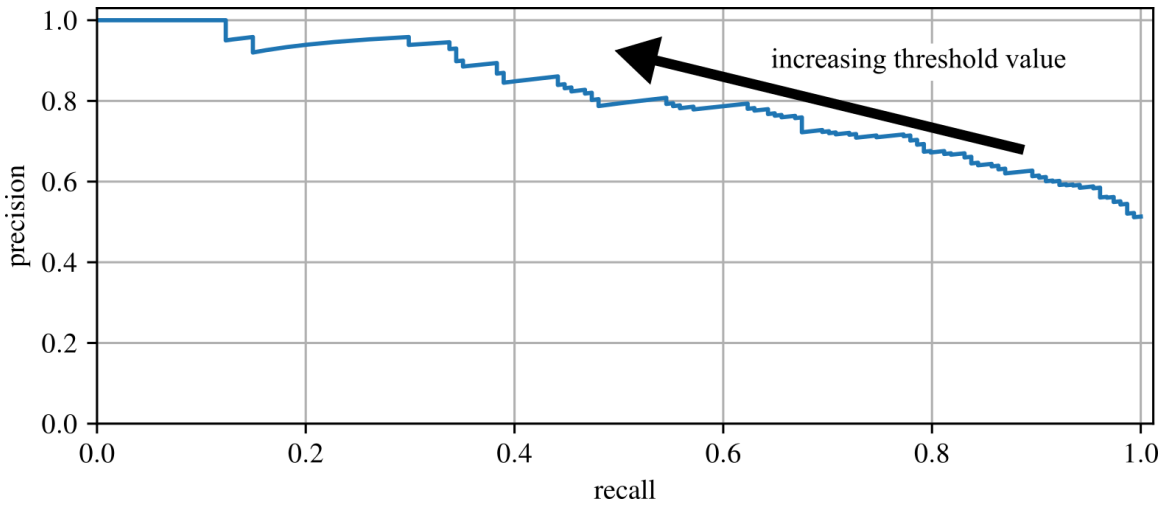

Figure 3.10: precision vs recall

By analyzing the curve, one can choose a threshold that balances precision and recall according to the specific needs of the application. For instance, in medical diagnosis, high recall is crucial to ensure no cases are missed, even if precision is lower. Additionally, the area under the precision-recall curve (AUC-PR) can be used to compare models. A higher area indicates a model with better performance across all thresholds.

3.3 k-fold Cross-validation

As you've likely observed, training your SGD classifier doesn't always yield consistent results in terms of model performance; hence the "stochastic" in stochastic gradient descent. One approach to obtaining a solution closer to the global minimum is to allow the gradient descent algorithm to iterate over more epochs. However, this poses a challenge as it's highly time-consuming and may lead to overfitting the model. Moreover, the variability in model performance makes it difficult to gauge the model's effectiveness.

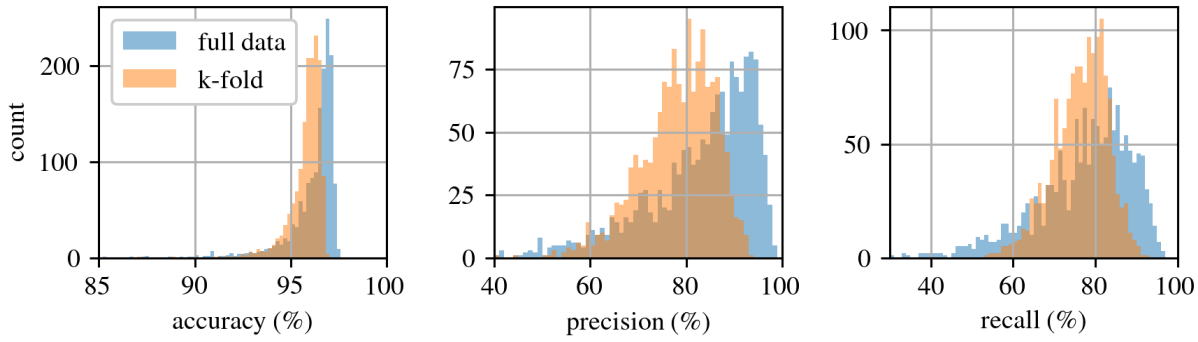

Figure 3.11: Performance metrics for 500 5-detectors trained either with full data or through k-fold cross-validation with 3 folds.

k-fold cross-validation offers a more rigorous method for evaluating your algorithm's performance. For instance, consider Figure 3.11, which depicts the performance metrics for 500 classification models trained as 5-detectors. Noticeably, the results obtained using k-fold cross-validation exhibit significantly less variability compared to training the classifier on the full dataset. In k-fold cross-validation, the training set is divided into smaller subsets for training and validation. The model is trained on these subsets and evaluated on the validation sets. Figure 3.12 provides a graphical representation of this technique.

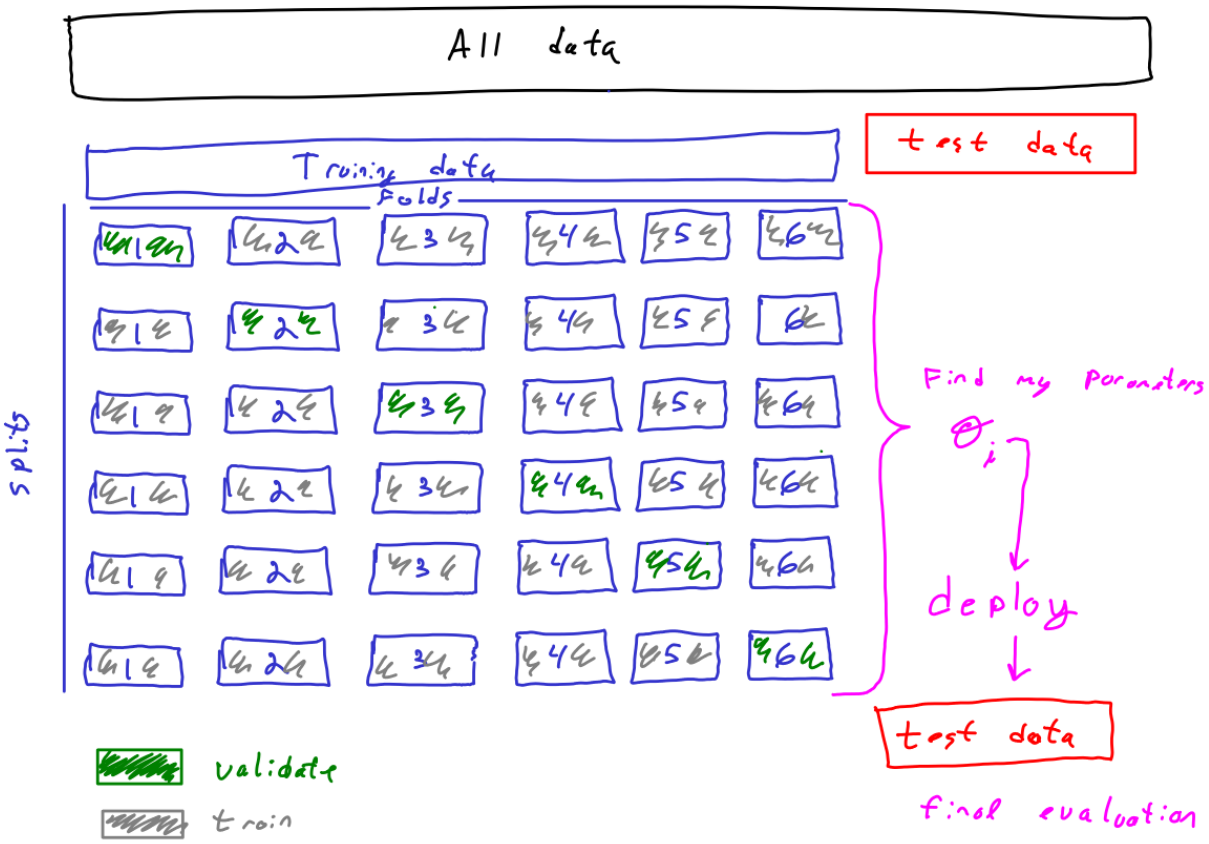

Figure 3.12: Illustration of how k-fold cross-validation operates.

Of course, Scikit-Learn provides a cross-validation feature, known as `sk.model_selection.cross_val_score`. This function conducts k-fold cross-validation by randomly partitioning the training set into distinct folds. Each fold is used for validation while the rest are used for training the SGD classifier. The reported performance metrics are averaged across all folds. It's important to note that by partitioning the data into folds, the number of samples available for learning is limited, which may result in peculiar classifiers with unusually high or low error rates. Despite being more computationally expensive, this approach effectively utilizes all the data for training and validation.

Example 3.5 Do example on k-fold Cross-validation using `sk.model_selection`

3.4 Multiclass Classification

Previously, we explored binary classifiers, which distinguish between two classes. Now, we'll explore the use of multiclass classifiers (also known as multinomial classifiers), which can discern between more than two classes. The simplest approach to multiclass classification involves multiple iterations of a binary classifier. There are two primary strategies for achieving this, both of which are considered in the context of the MNIST database challenge:

- **One-versus-Rest (OvR)**: This strategy involves creating a system capable of classifying digit images into 10 classes (from 0 to 9) by training 10 binary classifiers, one for each digit (e.g., a 0-detector, a 1-detector, a 5-detector, and so on). When classifying an image, the decision score from each classifier is obtained, and the class with the highest score is selected. While sometimes referred to as One-Versus-All (OvA), this term is slightly misleading as it does not involve comparisons against the same class.

- **One-versus-one (OvO)**: This approach trains a binary classifier for every pair of digits, such as one for distinguishing between 0s and 1s, another for distinguishing between 0s and 5s, and so forth. If there are N classes, $N \times (N-1)/2$ classifiers need to be trained. For the MNIST problem, this translates to training 45 binary classifiers. During classification, the image is evaluated against all 45 classifiers, and the class with the most victories is selected. The primary advantage of OvO is that each classifier only needs to be trained on the relevant portion of the training set for the two classes it distinguishes, which is beneficial for algorithms that scale poorly.

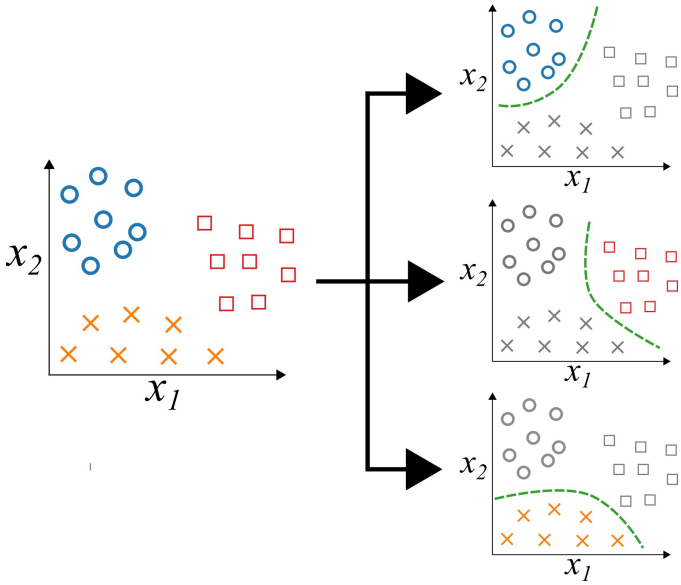

Figure 3.13: One-versus-Rest (OvR) classifier for a multi-class dataset.

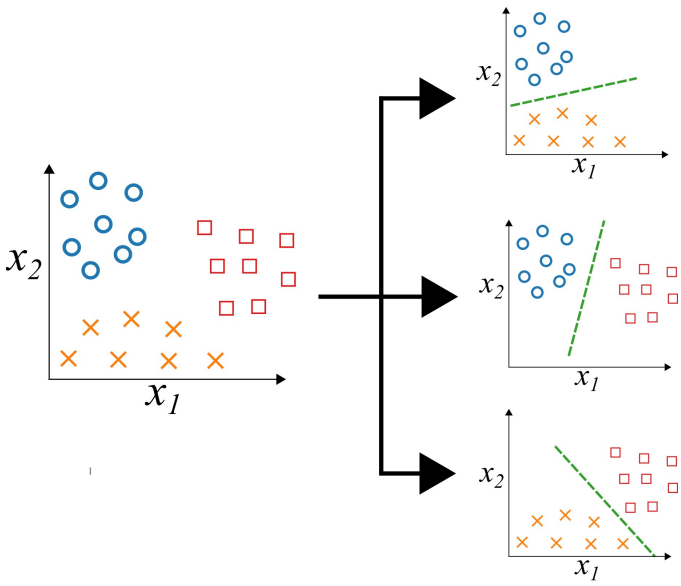

Figure 3.14: One-versus-one (OvO) classifier for a multi-class dataset.

Certain algorithms, such as Support Vector Machine classifiers, suffer from scalability issues with larger training sets. Consequently, OvO is preferred for such algorithms since it's faster to train numerous classifiers on small training sets compared to training a few classifiers on large training sets. However, for most binary classification algorithms, OvA is the preferred strategy. Nevertheless, some algorithms, such as Random Forest classifiers or naive Bayes classifiers, can handle multiple classes directly.

Example 3.6 Example of Multiclass Stochastic Gradient Descent.

3.5 Performance Measures for Multiclass Classification

Assessing a multiclass classifier often poses more challenges compared to evaluating a binary classifier. Nonetheless, many of the principles and methodologies utilized in evaluating binary classifiers can be seamlessly applied to multiclass classifiers as well.

3.5.1 Confusion Matrix

First, examine the confusion matrix. To do this, generate predictions using the `cross_val_predict()` function, followed by calling the `confusion_matrix()` function, similar to your previous steps:

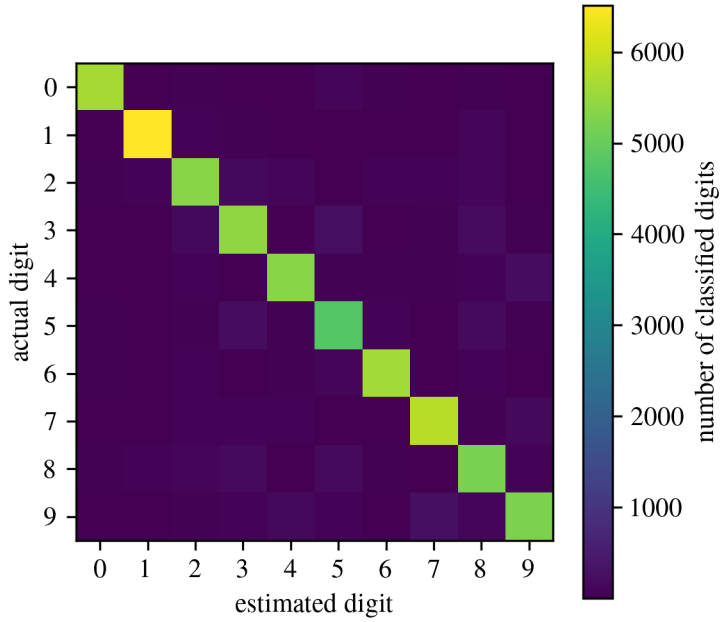

Figure 3.15: Confusion matrix for the MNIST data set solved using a one-vs-one classifier with Stochastic Gradient Descent and a k-fold of 3.

This confusion matrix appears satisfactory, with most images located on the main diagonal, indicating correct classification. However, the 5s appear slightly darker than other digits, suggesting fewer instances of 5s in the dataset or inferior performance of the classifier on 5s. Further investigation confirms both scenarios.

Let's refine the plot to focus on errors:

- Initially, divide each value in the confusion matrix by the number of images in the corresponding class to compare error rates instead of absolute numbers, which may unfairly bias abundant classes.
- Subsequently, replace the diagonal elements with NaNs to retain only the errors and visualize the result.

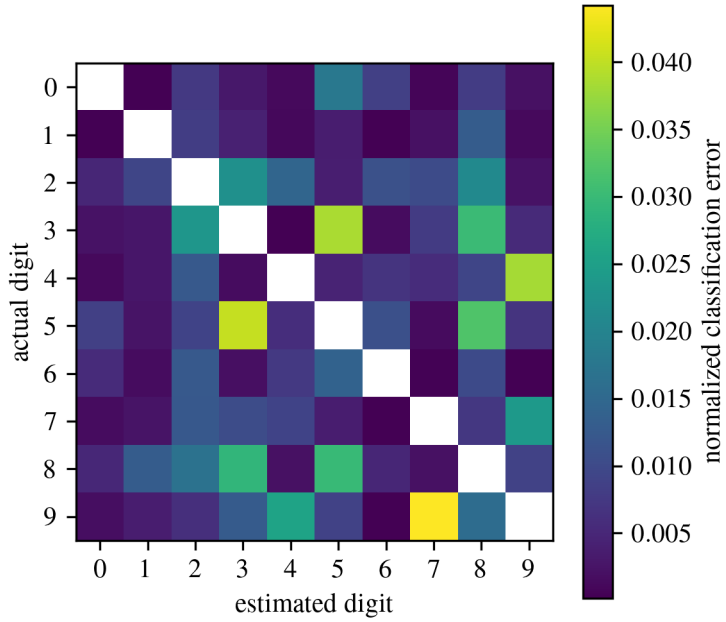

Figure 3.16: Normalized confusion matrix (similar to figure 3.15) with the diagonal removed to emphasize errors.

The refined plot facilitates a clear understanding of the classifier's error patterns. Rows represent actual classes, while columns depict predicted classes. Columns corresponding to classes 8 and 9 exhibit brightness, indicating numerous misclassifications as 8s or 9s. Likewise, rows for classes 8 and 9 also appear bright, signifying frequent confusion between 8s, 9s, and other digits. Conversely, some rows, like row 1, display darkness, indicating accurate classification of most 1s (with few exceptions confused with 8s). Notably, errors are asymmetric; for instance, more 5s are misclassified as 8s than vice versa.

Analyzing the confusion matrix provides valuable insights for classifier enhancement. In this case, efforts should concentrate on improving the classification of 8s and 9s, along with addressing the specific 3/5 confusion. Potential strategies include gathering more training data for these digits, devising new features (e.g., counting closed loops), or preprocessing images to emphasize distinguishing patterns (e.g., using Scikit-Image, Pillow, or OpenCV).

Example 3.7 Do example on multiclass confusion matrix.

3.5.2 Analyzing Individual Errors

Analyzing individual errors provides valuable insights into the classifier's behavior and reasons for its failures.

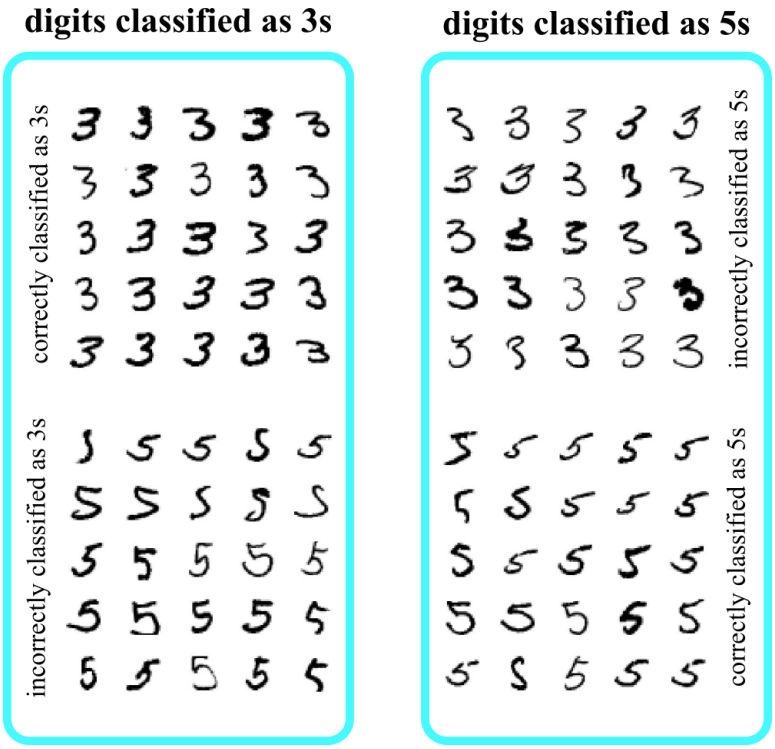

Figure 3.17: Confusion matrix showing digits classified as 3s and 5s for the same classifier used to obtain the results shown in figure 3.15.

The two 5×5 blocks on the left depict digits classified as 3s, while those on the right show images classified as 5s. Some misclassified digits (e.g., in the bottom-left and top-right blocks) are poorly written, challenging even for human classification (e.g., the digit resembling a 3 in the 8th row and 1st column). However, most misclassifications seem obvious to humans, making it difficult to comprehend why the classifier erred. This is because a simple SGDClassifier, being a linear model, assigns weights per class to each pixel and sums up the weighted pixel intensities to score each class. Consequently, since 3s and 5s differ by few pixels, this model easily confuses them.

The primary discrepancy between 3s and 5s lies in the position of the connecting line between the top line and bottom arc. Slight shifting or rotation of this junction can lead the classifier to misclassify a 3 as a 5, and vice versa. Thus, the classifier is sensitive to image shifting and rotation. To mitigate the 3/5 confusion, preprocessing the images to ensure proper centering and minimal rotation would be beneficial. This approach is likely to reduce other classification errors as well.